

ity, it's virtual reality, it's Web3 and the magic pixie dust—artificial intelligence and machine learning, which makes everything magical... When you put these potentially disruptive technologies together, interesting stuff is going to happen,” he said.

He opined that business leaders should not get carried away by the hype but should nevertheless start preparing for it, because it will gradually creep into our lives. Forrester analyst J.P. Gownder suggested that metaverse technology vendors need to be focused on the nuts and bolts of business fundamentals in 2023. “If they show a flashy demo but do not have any customers? That is a red flag,” he warned! According to him, enterprises might get more tangible benefits from using the metaverse for employee collaboration, training, onboarding, etc.

Edwina Fitzmaurice, a member of the World Economic Forum's Global Future Council, opined that enterprise interest in digital twins and collaboration might lead to highly-developed hardware. “I think we're going to see AR glasses come out for the first time in a meaningful way, supported by some really good apps,” she said.

Peggy Johnson, Chief Executive Officer at Magic Leap, an American company that develops augmented reality (AR) headsets, remarked that although there is a growth in the consumer sector, the enterprise market will remain more important to them till the prices of headsets can be brought down.

When fielding questions from the audience about what is blocking the metaverse's progress, most panellists agreed that one important factor was the absence of ‘Killer



*An image created by DALL-E, to the input: “An astronaut riding a horse in photorealistic style.” (Courtesy: OpenAI)*

Apps’ that encourage take-up of metaverse technology. Other points that came up were the need to work on human-centric experiences, interoperability, privacy, safety and ethics, and so on.

The panellists indicated that we are likely to see some real serious use cases soon, such as on-site use of digital twins for collaboration, design work and customer visualisations; use of AR in operating theatres, giving surgeons three-dimensional (3D) visualisations during medical procedures (Magic Leap recently received the safety certification for use as medical electrical equipment), and so on. In his closing comments, Neil Trevett advised decision makers not to get left behind the metaverse hype cycle, but to be a part of it instead.

There were more such panel discussions and talks dedicated to different aspects of the metaverse, such as the creator economy and non-fungible tokens (NFTs), metaverse and gaming, Web3, challenges and opportunities, and so on. In one such panel discussion, experts

opined that it is time to break free from terrifying jargon like non-fungible tokens, and focus on application based terms that are easy on the user too.

For example, many brands prefer to call NFTs as digital collectibles, a term that resonates better with the user. For the metaverse to succeed, companies should focus on user-centric experiences, rather than showing off the technology or terminology.

As Kirthiga Reddy, Co-founder and CEO of Virtualness, a Web3 marketing agency, remarked during another event in February this year, “People do not

care about the underlying technology. They care about how to use it. Clients do not care about NFTs, they care that NFTs allow them to have much stronger connections to their customers.” On a similar strain, Cathy Hackl, Chief Metaverse Officer of Web3 consultancy company Journey, remarked in a CES panel discussion that, “Bridging the digital and physical in an unremarkable, everyday kind of way, with unremarkable everyday technology is actually the core [of the metaverse].”

At the event, the Blockchain Association discussed how blockchain technology and cryptocurrency can underpin many of the technological trends forecasted for the year ahead. According to a report released by Accenture at CES 2023, the metaverse industry could potentially be worth as much as US\$ 1 trillion by 2025 thanks to growing interest in the metaverse as a tool for creators and as a means of enhancing daily life. The findings indicate that more than half of the 9,000 consumers surveyed see the metaverse as a business opportunity for creating